Supplementary File 5 : Additional responses from participants in the multifaceted survey.

Supplementary Table 5.1 Additional responses from participants on factors affecting rural shrinkage and potential solutions – the Germany case.

	Social Factors	**Economic Factors**	**Ecological Factors**
Lüneburg:	• A mixed presence of willingness and opportunities to integrate new Germans. • The "church tower mentality" – a lack of networking skills and narrow-mindedness. • The absence of a clear master plan or objectives, and the difficulty of finding a role for the district under the leadership of a mayor with limited vision. • Local authorities in Lower Saxony demonstrate a lack of knowledge about rural development because of the state government's decisions to decentralize planning powers.	• General infrastructure problems and urbanization affect the region. • Poor connections to public transportation, schools, education, and job opportunities. • Decline in jobs in agriculture, handicrafts, and the social sector. • Geographical disadvantages due to remote location from central hubs. • Inadequate internet connections hinder connectivity.	• Soil quality is unsuitable for agriculture. • Agricultural practices damage the landscape and, ironically, prevent shrinkage.
Lüchow-Dannenberg:	• Lack of appeal or expectations for young people. • Decline in real social contact due to digitalization. • Top-down policies and local thinking limit broader development perspectives. • "Excess deaths" births and migration are insufficient to compensate for the number of deaths.	• Labor supply shortages and inadequate infrastructure. • Scarcity of jobs and lower wages compared to other regions. • Delays in integrating technological developments such as broadband internet.	• Positive ecological factors contributing to a decrease in the rate of decline. • Ecological diversity slows down the decline process by attracting people to the region. • The ecological appeal of the region serves as a motivating factor for people to move here.
Solutions and Recommendations	• Establishing research institutions or incubators in rural areas to encourage innovation. • Providing specific recommendations on settlement development, considering the unique needs of rural and urban areas. • Encouraging intergenerational housing projects to increase community integration. • Improving infrastructure and transport links, including car-free transport options. • Creating local job opportunities with reliable internet connections. • Strengthening internal potential and promoting soft tourism. • Developing environmentally friendly initiatives, including family-friendly and age-appropriate public transportation connections. •Advocating ecological irrigation management and promoting sustainable agricultural practices through increased processing of primary products.		

Supplementary Table 5.2. Additional responses from participants on factors affecting rural shrinkage and potential solutions - the Türkiye case

Social Factors	Economic Factors	Ecological Factors
• The decline in farming has increased migration from village to cities. • Lack of education policies. • Absence of effective policies and practices regarding rural issues. • Migration for job opportunities, primarily to Lüleburgaz (2 similar responses). • The appeal of an easy and effortless life. • Young people prefer an easy life and want to live in comfortable city homes.	• Policies directly affect the agriculture and livestock sectors. • Accessibility issues affecting rural livelihoods. • Increasing costs and burdens on agriculture and livestock (two similar responses). • Closure of local factories, reduction in employment opportunities. • Difficult farming conditions in villages and low financial returns from agriculture. • Ineffectiveness of agricultural support institutions such as agricultural chambers and oilseed cooperatives.	• Challenges faced by farmers due to the use of foreign seeds. • The misuse of pasture areas negatively impacts small livestock farming. • Dry winter seasons lead to excessively dry summer conditions, affecting agricultural productivity.
Recommendations: • Ensuring that production incentives supported by state aid are implemented effectively and are practical, not merely theoretical. • Removing Special Consumption Taxes to alleviate the financial burden on producers in rural areas. • Developing social and commercial areas such as cafes, restaurants, personal care facilities, and shopping centers to attract and retain the young population in rural areas.		